

Speed of Tape (Instant)

Indicators & Analysis / Volume & Delta | intermediate | 4 min read | DeepCharts Help Center | July 16, 2026

Speed of Tape (Instant) measures instantaneous trade execution speed — how much is trading right now within a short rolling time window. Bar height shows how fast the tape is running; bar color shows whether buying or selling pressure dominates the flow being measured.

Where the standard Speed of Tape indicator plots pace as a historical series, the Instant variant keeps you focused on the last few readings, making it a real-time urgency gauge for active trading.

The streaming tape below is the raw flow this indicator distills — watch the buy/sell/delta counters shift as prints roll in, and filter by All/Ask/Bid to isolate one side.

[WIDGET: tape-lab]

What it is

The indicator analyzes volume flow over a configurable window (**Number of seconds**, default **10**) and draws the result as colored bars: green/teal bars mark positive-delta periods where buying pressure dominates, red/pink bars mark negative-delta periods where selling pressure dominates, and bar height reflects trading velocity intensity. By default only the most recent readings are shown (**Bars to show**, default **3**), keeping the display anchored to the present.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Chart with Speed of Tape (Instant) active — the three most recent tape-speed bars visible, tallest bar in the buy color during a fast push up, price candles moving in the background
speed-of-tape-instant-chart-overview.png

When to use it

- You confirm momentum in real time: sudden tape-speed spikes in the direction of your trade validate the entry.
- You watch for exhaustion: bars progressively shortening while price extends warns the move is running out of participation.
- You identify acceleration phases: progressively taller bars flag institutional-scale urgency building.
- You recognize consolidation: persistently low velocity tells you to expect chop rather than follow-through.

Quick start

1. Open the **Indicator List** on your chart and add **Speed of Tape (Instant)**.
2. Open the indicator's **Settings**.
3. Keep **Input data** on **Volume** (the default) to weight speed by traded size (see Different Types of Input Data for Indicators).
4. Leave **Number of seconds** at the default **10** and **Display value** on **Total** — this aggregates all trading activity within each 10-second window.
5. Keep **Bars to show** at the default **3**; increase it only if you want more recent history in view.

[SCREENSHOT PLACEHOLDER] Speed of Tape (Instant) settings dialog — Plot Settings with Bars to show = 3 and Scale min value = 0, Data Settings and Mode Settings sections visible with Number of seconds = 10
speed-of-tape-instant-settings.png

How to read it

- **Tall bar, buy color** — heavy activity dominated by buying pressure; momentum confirmation for longs.

- **Tall bar, sell color** — the same urgency on the sell side.
- **Bars shrinking across readings** — an exhaustion signal: each window is quieter than the last even if price is still drifting.
- **Bars growing across readings** — an acceleration phase; breakouts starting on rising tape speed carry more weight.
- **Uniformly short bars** — low velocity, typical of consolidation; signals from other tools fire less reliably here.

Remember the color encodes delta dominance within the measured window, not the direction of the current candle — a red speed bar can print while price ticks up if sellers dominate the executed flow.

Settings reference

Plot Settings

Setting	What it does
Bars to show	How many historical bars of Speed of Tape data are displayed on the chart. Default 3 .
Scale min value	Establishes the baseline for the visual representation of tape speed. Default 0 .

General (Candle Settings)

Setting	What it does
Line width	Bar thickness for visibility. Default 1 .
Plot reversed	Reverses the vertical orientation of the bars when enabled.
Delta Positive	Color for positive-delta (buy-dominant) bars. Default green/teal.
Delta Negative	Color for bars representing negative-delta periods.
Delta Positive (Secondary) / Delta Negative (Secondary)	Additional color options for each side.

Data Settings

Setting	What it does
Input data	Data source: Volume (default) or Order flow data. See Different Types of Input Data for Indicators.
Filter min	Excludes low-activity periods from the calculation.
Filter max	Caps extremely high activity periods. Default 0 (no limit).

Mode Settings

Setting	What it does
Display value	How activity in the window is summarized. Default Total — aggregates all trading activity within the specified time window.
Number of seconds	The time window in seconds over which tape speed is calculated. Default 10 .

Tips and common mistakes

- **Ten seconds is a sensible default — but not sacred.** Scalpers on very fast symbols may prefer a shorter window; slower instruments read better with a longer one. Change one thing at a time.

- **Do not treat color as a trade signal.** The delta coloring shows who dominated the measured flow; direction still needs price and structure to confirm.
- **Keep Bars to show small.** The indicator's value is its immediacy — turning it into a long history duplicates what Speed of Tape already does better.
- **Use Filter min to mute noise on thin markets,** where a handful of small trades can otherwise register as meaningless "speed."

Related articles

- [Speed of Tape](#)
- [Delta Bar](#)
- [Big Trades](#)
- [Orderflow 101: Bid, Ask, Aggressor and Delta](#)
- [Different Types of Input Data for Indicators](#)
- [How to Change the Layout of Indicators](#)